Oak Oracle

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Mature

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by WordsAreThereToBeRead

Summary

Catra moved into a new town and wants to explore the local park to relax and practise her arts. She finds herself utterly distracted, though, by an alluring woman with a ponytail. The arrival of unwelcome visitors sets in motion a chain of events that will have turned upside down Catra's life by the end of the day.

Notes

Just a reminder: having differently coloured eyes is called heterochromia iridis.

Chapter 1

Catra feels the warm air on her face as she steps onto the pavement, sketchbook and pencil case in hand. Hearing the door behind her snapping shut, she hastily checks the pockets of her jeans for the keys. She doesn't want to start a new life in a new city with locking herself out. Hidden beneath a tissue, today's grocery list and receipt, her fingers finally get hold of the cold metal. She exhales and allows herself to relax.

Yesterday evening, the heavy rain nearly soaked the few cardboard boxes she needed to store her belongings in on the short way from the rental car to the front door. This morning, when she went shopping in order to fill her fridge, it was still cloudy and chilly. Now, with noon about two hours ago, the sun is shining from a clear sky, and Catra is eager to visit the nearest park. Well-fed by a tasty self-cooked mushroom risotto, she hopes to spend a few hours in a calm environment and add one or two drawings to her portfolio. Depending on the subject and the level of detail she feels necessary, she might even get home with three.

Her phone tells her the walk will be seventeen minutes. She follows the route to the point and without letting the yet unknown urban surroundings distract her. Architecture and sightseeing never were of much interest to Catra. She prefers the organic shapes and chaotic arrangements of natural growth.

After just fifteen minutes, she reaches her destination. The park, which she expects to be a rectangle of neatly trimmed grass and a tree here and there, is hidden by an ageing red brick wall. When she reaches the wall's opening, she is very much delighted to see a vast variety of flowers, shrubs and trees of a full-blown botanical garden. While the lush green of all kinds of leaves and stems is dominant, blossoms paint the scenery in every colour of the rainbow.

Catra enters and stops after a few steps. Most of the city noise is warded off by the wall, and it seems not many people bothered to

come here today. The reason why eludes Catra, but she gladly accepts the fact and stops to take it all in: the gravel beneath her bare feet, the soft rustling of the leaves, the mixture of scents, the sunlight on her back, the wind around her ears, the songs of birds.

Today is a good day.

For a while, Catra strolls along the winding paths throughout the garden, not looking for anything in particular. She learns that the garden is divided in several differently themed areas, separated by densely growing shrubs and bushes.

On her way along an evenly curved path, she approaches one of the gardens many benches that invite to sit, relax and enjoy. Most of them are unoccupied. The bench Catra is approaching now, however, is taken by a woman, who is about Catra's age. She is sitting cross-legged and with a hunched back on the seat, her dark blonde ponytail dangling down the side of her neck. Her elbows rest on her thighs, fists pointing up and supporting her head. In her lap lies an open book, and headphones cover her ears. She wears a white polo neck and grey leggings that accents her athletic build. A breath of air carries the faint scent of lavender. Catra is mesmerized.

Today got even better.

Not able to take her eyes off of the woman she spontaneously names Miss Park, Catra is torn between wanting her to look up and fearing getting caught staring. Miss Park is seemingly so absorbed in her book and her music that she doesn't stir. Catra involuntarily runs her fingers through her hair when she passes Miss Park. She hates it when her body language gives her away, but she could only do so much and stop her tail from swaying. When a savoury scent – definitely not of floral origin – hits Catra's nose, she bites her lip to fight the urge to moan.

With Miss Park out of sight, Catra is able to regain her senses. She snickers internally to herself about the ridiculous intensity of this

short encounter and how thrilled she is by the chance to run across Miss Park again – who might live just nearby and be a regular guest.

Catra follows the path, a line of shrubs on her right side, until she reaches an unoccupied bench to her left and close to the garden's brick wall. The path continues through the shrubbery until it vanishes behind a sharp curve. Two huge trees frame the bench. They each have a trunk that could easily hide Catra and brown bark with deep fissures. Their leaves are lobed and rather on the slender side. While not being especially proficient regarding trees, Catra is sure these impressive specimens are English oaks.

All in all, the flora secludes the bench so well that Catra feels like being in a rich green sanctuary. She's tempted to stay here for today, hopefully in peace. Due to the lack of any colourful flowers and blossoms, however, there's not much visual variety to inspire her art. Then again, she might as well draw a detailed study of leaves, buds or entangled twigs.

Catra decides to sit down on the bench. Due to her lowered perspective, a hole in the foliage reveals Miss Park sitting on her bench in the distance. The leaves framing the sight create the illusion of looking at a photograph. Although Miss Park is too far away to study her features, Catra is content with staring at her face from afar.

Perfect spot.

Eventually, Catra decides to give the plants their share of attention and lets her eyes wander. She looks at the leaves closest to her, looks for an interesting composition for a study. An involuntary glance at Miss Park. *Maybe no leaves today.* Catra focuses instead on a bush that apparently needs some more time to fully bring out its green and thus sports an abundance of buds. They are interesting enough, but it doesn't click. A lingering gaze on Miss Park. *I'm so weak.* Reminding herself that drawing is not just a fun pastime, rather an investment in the future, her future, Catra checks the twigs and branches that are not mostly hidden by

leaves. *Ugh.* She hates those. They are not inherently difficult to draw, but she always struggles with composition.

A squirrel scurries through the shrubbery. Its russet fur looks fluffy, especially the tail. Every so often it stops, stands on its back legs and sniffs the air, wiggles its nose. It hops onto the path not far to Catra's left. Catra never has seen one so close, and it seems inclined to come even closer. In a quick succession of dash and stop, dash and stop, it approaches Catra's left foot. She dares not to breathe. Is it looking for food? Probably. Although Catra does not speak squirrel, it might actually expect a treat. Only when it continues along the path and darts up the tree to Catra's right, she exhales audibly.

So cute, Catra thinks. Not the only source of cuteness, though. She sighs, gives in to her craving and plants a full-on stare on Miss Park. Who is still reading her book, but also bobbing her head up and down, sometimes to the side, so her ponytail chaotically sways around. Is she headbanging? Her appearance doesn't give it away – or, if anything, it looks too tame –, but Catra doesn't give a shit and the rhythm might actually fit.

A conveniently spacious jeans pocket releases phone and headphones. Catra looks through her playlists to find a suitably paced piece, decides on *Symphony Of Destruction* and fires it up. Once the prelude is over and the beat hits her ears, Catra smiles: it perfectly syncs with Miss Park's movements. Catra's head moves along. Much to her disappointment, Miss Park's headbanging – real or imagined – stops before the song in Catra's ears is halfway through.

That doesn't stop Catra from staring, though. At Miss Park. Who sits up. Who starts to stretch her arms and torso. Who looks over in Catra's direction. Maybe right through the frame. Probably seeing her stupid grin and her headbanging. Miss Park smiles.

Fuck.

Catra zones out while her stomach rides the rollercoaster and her heart goes on a rampage. Until something blocks her view. Snapping back to reality, Catra sees two people walking along the path in front of her. She doesn't move her eyes, but given the general shape she can make out even from the corner of her eye, given the excessive sway of shoulders, the steps too wide for the length of the legs, the talking that is way louder than necessary, the sweeping gestures, the sardonic laughter – given all that, Catra has no doubt to have spotted two teenage boys who think the world resolves around them.

The smile on Catra's face turns into scowl, her hair stands on end, and she grinds her teeth. How dare they invade her sanctuary. She only hopes for them to pass quickly, but at their slow pace, that's not going to happen. Well, at least her view of Miss Park is clear again – who returned to reading her book.

Catra rubs her forehead and grumbles to herself. What maybe was a dumb idea, because the boys who were almost swallowed by the shrubbery again, stop in their tracks. One of them turns around, comes over and sits on the bench. On her fucking bench. Who dares to say something to her – which she can't understand because *Symphony Of Destruction* is still vibrant in her ears. She thinks about playing the song to the face of the little shit. With her fists.

Well, technically, they didn't do anything. Yet. Catra's breathing is shallow, her abs tense, her shoulders hunched. Through sheer force of will she manages to take off her headphones. “What?” she asks with as little disdain as possible. She does not look at him, but can see him turning to his sidekick who stayed on the path.

He turns back to her. “I said: nice tail, cutie.” The last word obviously meaning 'freak'. So much for today being a good day.

Catra is on the verge of swiping the smug grin he most definitely shows right now from his face. With her claws. “Leave me alone,” she says through gritted teeth.

The boy sways back a little and brings his arms up in defence. “Relax, girl! You just get wrinkles when you frown like that.” He leans forward again, farther than before. “And, you know, that's kind of a rude way to say 'thank you' for a compliment.” His pal, the coward in the background, snickers.

Catra fumes with rage and tries to remember her anger management training, but she can't concentrate. “Listen, kid,” she hisses, “why don't you do yourself a favour and head back to your nursery and play with your toys, hm?”

For a second, the little shit is frozen in place, and Catra hopes to endure this without losing her temper and ruining her life. Again. Alas, he misunderstood her advice as a challenge, straightens his back, puffs up his chest, arms akimbo. Just as he opens his mouth, the sidekick shouts “fuck” and hits his insolent pal on the shoulder.

Catra risks a look at the little shit and sees him turning to the coward, then towards the path they came from. His eyes grow wide and his jaw drops in shock. A moment later, he jumps up and, together with the coward, runs for his petty life to quickly vanish between the shrubs to Catra's left.

Curious, but not ready to relax, Catra looks down the path to her right. Her eyes, too, grow wide. Miss Park strides along the path, clenched fists at her sides, mouth a thin line, piercing eyes. Hand her a spear and she'd look like a fucking Valkyrie.

Ready to kill.

Catra gasps and gets goosebumps. If Miss Park gave her this look, Catra would run as well or climb a tree. Lucky for her, that's not the case, and she drinks in the presence Miss Park radiates. She owns this place.

Miss Park slows her pace, the tenseness on her face fades. She closes her eyes and lowers her head for two steps before she looks back up, turns to Catra and offers a ginger smile.

Catra is lost. She tells herself it's the sudden change in emotions, the high level of stress, but seeing Miss Park's face transform from fury, directed at those scumbags, to sympathy, apparently directed at Catra, makes her heart flutter. As much as she likes having Miss Park's attention on her, Catra's knees would give away right now if she wasn't already seated. Still, she feels dizzy, exhales deeply and slumps against the bench's backrest.

Miss Park approaches the bench with soft steps. She's so close that Catra dares not to look at her. “May I sit down?” Miss Park asks.

Catra clears her throat and nods. “Sure.” Her eyes follow Miss Park's legs, her very muscular legs, while they move to the left-hand side of the bench. Miss Park sits down on the edge, halfway facing Catra and about an arm's reach away. Catra finds the courage to take a look at the pair of blue eyes fixed on her. She smiles weakly.

“You okay?” Miss Park leans forward slightly. “You look a little pale.”

When Catra casts her eyes down, she notices the cream cloth bag hanging from Miss Park's right shoulder. Of course, she won't leave her stuff on the other bench for someone to steal it. Then again, she might be up for a short stay.

Catra takes another deep breath. “Yeah, I'm fine. Thanks. I guess it's just the adrenalin.” She looks at Miss Park again who nods once. “I'm really glad you showed up,” Catra continues. “I mean, I could have handled those pricks. Problem is, I nearly did just that.”

Miss Park raises her brows. “Problem?”

“Well,” Catra says and holds up her left hand, “these are not just for show.” She extends her claws. Miss Park jerks back with a faint yelp. Which is cute. “Sorry,” Catra says and lowers her hand.

“It's alright,” Miss Park giggles. Adorably so. “I can see you can take care of yourself. You made quite the impression.”

Catra does not know how to respond. She catches her mouth gape.

“On the bench,” Miss Park helps and indicates with her eyes to the spot between them. Catra follows the lead and finds four deep scratches in the wood of the bench's seat.

“Fuck.” Catra sighs. “That's exactly the problem I'm talking about. Sometimes I lose it and get myself into trouble. And even though I despise those little shits, I hate hurting people. Once, in school, I got into a fight with an older girl and nearly scratched her left eye out.” Miss Park presses her lips together. “Sorry,” Catra continues, “I didn't mean to unload my crap onto you. Thanks again. And also sorry for cursing that much, I know it annoys people.”

“Don't mention it. I'm glad I could help.” Miss Park lays her bag aside, slides back on the seat, pulls her ankles up to sit cross-legged and rests her back against the bench.

Catra is undecided what makes Miss Park stay. Is it her urge to protect in light of Catra's display of nervousness, or may Catra hope for mutual attraction? Either way, she intends to extend the stay. “Anyway,” Catra says, “you made quite the impression yourself.”

“Did I?” Miss Park turns to Catra so her right thigh touches the backrest from hip to knee. She places her elbow onto the topmost beam and leans her head against her knuckles. “Are you talking about the boys or yourself?” She smirks.

Wow, she's bold, Catra thinks and decides to play along. “Yes.” She grins and feels her cheeks heat up. Miss Park's hearty laugh resonates in Catra's stomach. Or somewhere below. “Seriously though. Those guys almost peed themselves when you rode into battle. Are you some sort of superhero?” Miss Park's laughter

grows louder. She even snorts and doesn't bother to cover her mouth. Catra giggles like a teenager and realizes, she might be falling for Miss Park a tad too quickly and too deeply.

Miss Park shakes her head and sends her ponytail dancing. “I guess,” she says and presents her right fist, “they just remembered the impression my knuckles had on them.”

Catra's eyes widen and switch between Miss Park's face and her fist. Whose thumbnail is varnished in red and orange – each colour covers half of the nail. “You literally beat them up?” Catra points to where the little shits vanished.

“Well,” Miss Park says while the happiness in her face gives way to sorrow, “I'm not particularly fond of the memory, so I probably shouldn't have made fun of it in the first place.”

“Sorry, I didn't mean to make you uncomfortable.”

“Nah, don't worry. You couldn't know, and also it relates to what you told me earlier, so I'm fine with sharing.” She hesitates.

Catra is curious enough to be interested and caring enough to not turn Miss Park down. And, if she's honest with herself, she knows that sharing bad memories helps people getting close. So she nods in encouragement.

Miss Park smiles weakly – Catra returns it – before continuing. “One evening, about one and a half year ago, I was on my way to the gym. I usually walk along the main street because it's the shortest route. That day, however, I was feeling adventurous and decided to just head into the general direction and explore the neighbourhood. I quickly got a bad feeling, but it took a while for me to figure out why. Everything looked more and more desolate. Older cars, more graffiti, litter on the streets, cracks in the walls, that kind of stuff.”

“Yeah, I totally know what you mean. Grew up in one of those shitty places.” Catra pulls her left leg up and turns in her seat towards Miss Park.

“Sorry to hear. I can't imagine what it's like to be a kid there. Makes me feel bad to be, well, a privileged bitch.”

“Don't, it's not your fault. I was lucky enough to get out early enough.” Catra smiles in a hopefully reassuring way. “Please continue with your story.”

Miss Park nods. “The street I was walking down was particularly miserable. Maybe half of the streetlamps where broken. It was November and dark. I heard some noises I couldn't place at first. Could have been a TV. Only when I got close to a small alley leading to the backyard of what looked like an abandoned building, it clicked in my head and I knew someone was getting beaten up. So I just dropped my bag and dashed into the yard.”

Catra groans, and her hair stands on end. “I know you made it out in one piece, but it still gives me the creeps.”

“I got out alright, but the gay kid didn't.”

“Fuck.”

“At the time I reached the yard, I saw him lying on the floor, one leg twisted so much I got sick on the spot. And those two ... those two fuckers you had the pleasure to meet were all over him, kicking madly at him like they wanted to kill him.”

Catra could see Miss Park's eyes getting wet. “That's probably what they had in mind.” She grits her teeth until it hurts.

“That's what I figured. So I lost it for a moment and didn't hold back.” She takes a deep breath. “I spare us the details. To cut a long story short, the kid they beat up made it, but he spent weeks in the hospital and will probably limp for the rest of his life.” A tear makes it down to Miss Park's cheek before she wipes it away with her sleeve.

“Shit. I'm so sorry.” Catra wants to reach out and touch Miss Park, hug her, but she doesn't know if she's allowed to. She bears it.

“Well, those two? They carried away some bruises, but they got away from me that evening and from the law overall. The kid was too scared to tell anybody what had happened, so I couldn't do anything to get them to court. I tried, even if it meant to probably face charges myself. But in the end no one bothered, and I eventually gave up.”

“I have no words for how much this sucks.”

“Trust me, me neither. Excuse me.” Miss Park grabs her bag, produces a tissue and blows her nose. “Anyway. From time to time I pity them, because I know they grew up in broken homes. And they almost were kids themselves. Thinking about what I might have done to them if I hadn't been able to get a hold of myself eventually makes me hate myself. And now I see they are still full of shit and apparently happy about it!” She throws her hands into the air. “I nearly lost it again.”

“Please don't hate yourself,” Catra says in a low voice. “I mean, don't let me tell you how you should treat yourself. But even though I don't know you, my gut tells me you're alright.”

“Thanks. That's sweet of you.” Miss Park finally smiles again, making Catra hold her breath. She presses her palms onto her eyes before she looks at Catra again. “So, that's my way of telling you that I can totally relate how you feel about hurting people.” They share a chuckle.

“I was wondering,” Catra says, “how did you notice what was going on here? This place is pretty isolated.”

“I had a feeling,” Miss Park says and pats her belly. “I didn't notice right away, but I saw the look on your face, like you were about to murder someone.”

“Right on the spot there.” Shivers run down Catra's spine.

“Yeah. That caught my attention, and I listened. I remembered their voices, then, and my gut told me they were up to no good.”

“And then you took your cape and went to kick some ass.”

“Stop that,” Miss Park says. The way she does, though, makes Catra believe she doesn't want her to stop.

“You must be good at reading people, then?” Catra asks.

“Uh, not usually, no. Often times I'm the last one to pick up on something.” Miss Park scratches her head. “Why?”

Catra raises her brows. “Oh, well, I'm quite fond of my poker face. Most of the time I don't like people to know how, you know, I feel and stuff. But maybe I delude myself and I just scare people enough for them to not bother.” She shrugs.

“I see. Maybe a coincidence.”

“Yeah.” *Or it's just that you in particular can read me well.* Catra's cheeks glow once more, and she grows a sudden interest in the tree towering behind Miss Park. Who apparently catches Catra's glance and looks over her shoulder.

“Say, do you know what this place is?” Miss Park swirls her finger around in a full circle.

“Uh, the botanical garden?” Catra guesses.

“No.” Miss Park clucks her tongue. “I mean this place right here. The bench, the trees.”

Catra raises her brows. “Sorry, I have no idea. I just moved here. Yesterday, actually.”

Miss Park's face lights up, and she claps her hands once. “That's great! Welcome to our city, I hope you settle in well.”

“Thanks,” Catra says and, for the second time this day, can't keep herself from running her fingers through her hair. “It's been really nice so far.” She coughs. “Mostly, anyway.”

“Happy to hear.” Miss Park beams. “I'm delighted, then, to introduce you the most famous local myth. This,” she says with emphasis, “is called the Oak Oracle.” She gives Catra an eager look.

Catra raises a brow. “Don't say they can talk or something. As much as I like these, I'd not be particularly comfortable sitting between Ents.”

Miss Park chuckles. “Nah, though I think that would be cool. Anyway. According to the myth, the Oak Oracle bestows a vision upon those couples who prove themselves worthy and perform the ritual by sharing their first kiss on this bench.”

“Right,” Catra stretches the word. She does give in to picture performing the ritual right now and forces herself to not look at Miss Park's lips. “And how, in theory, would I prove myself worthy?”

“That, unfortunately, is the part the myth remains exceptionally silent about.”

“Yeah. Honestly, it sounds like a story made up by a frustrated single. Even if not, does 'couple' indicate it can only ever be two persons? Do they have to be a couple already when they kiss for the first time? And does it work on this specific bench only? It's as good as new. Well, apart from the scratches. Sorry about those, botanic garden officials.”

Miss Park shows a weak smile. “Don't nail me down on the exact phrasing. It's not like there's an abundance of written traditions. And of course no one actually takes this seriously. Still, it has a romantic touch to it.” Miss Park seems interested in the shrubs across the path and fiddles with the sleeve of her shirt.

Catra has trouble to decode the mixed signals she gets. Has she just fucked up by dissing the myth which kind of sounded like an invitation to kiss? Her gut feeling is no help, because it tells her to

run and hide. “So, you're telling me about this myth because ...?” Catra tries what she hopes is the safe approach.

“Oh, er, well, as you can probably imagine,” Miss Park says and tucks a loose strand of hair back behind her ear, “this place is quite popular by the younger folk. And to some of those, sitting here all alone is seen as an invitation.”

Yeah, fuck, I botched that, Catra thinks. “That's why you picked to bench over there?” she asks and points her right thumb over the shoulder without looking. “So you don't get the wrong kind of attention?”

“Yep. Which is a shame, because it's a nice place after all.” Miss Park rocks her torso back and forth.

“I see. Well, thanks for the warning. I picked the place because I expected it to be quiet. Helps me with drawing.”

“Oh,” Miss Park's face shines once more, “you draw? Like comics, landscapes or ...?” She waves her hands around in circles.

“Mostly nature. Like plants, fruits. Landscapes only occasionally. Sometimes animals, though only from reference photos because the buggers tend to move. Unless they are dead, of course, but I don't like drawing dead stuff.”

“Yeah, I can relate.”

“I've done a few comic characters, but I'm rarely satisfied with the outcome.”

“Maybe you can show me sometime? I'm curious which outcome does satisfy your standards.”

Catra hesitates – her sketchbook is rather personal. Miss Park's interest seems genuine, though, and Catra feels she has to make up for the myth disaster. All remaining resistance is molten away by Miss Park's smile. Catra grabs the sketchbook and reaches out. “You can take a look, if you want.”

“Of course!” Miss Park grabs the sketchbook and opens it with great care. Her blue eyes still linger in Catra's mind. “Wow, they are really detailed, and the shadows add so much depth.”

Catra doesn't pay much attention to which drawing Miss Park is looking at. She's mesmerized by Miss Park's fingers or, more specifically, by the tenderness with which the turns the pages, by the caressing touch of her tips running along the book's edges. Catra bites her lip. A breeze strokes her face. It carries the scent of lavender – and another scent she has smelled only once before. She moans. Shocked by her own very indecent behaviour, Catra quickly regains control and clears her throat. If Miss Park sees through the attempted deception, she doesn't give it away.

Looking at Miss Park's fingernails – varnished from index to pinky in yellow, green, royal blue and violet –, Catra suddenly detects a pattern. “Rainbow, huh?” she asks.

Miss Park looks up. “Sorry?”

“Your fingernails.”

“Oh, yeah.” Miss Park shows a toothy grin and brings up her right hand and aligns its nails in a not so straight line, presenting the six colours of the rainbow flag. “So ...”

“Look at the back cover of my book,” Catra answers the unspoken question and grins.

Miss Park turns the sketchbook around. A rainbow-coloured back cover. “That's so cool! I'm always happy to see our local community grow. If your interested, that is.” Is that a blush on her cheeks?

Catra avoids people she doesn't feel comfortable around whenever possible. But the incentive so far is rather tempting. “I might be. You have any regular gatherings or so?”

“More or less, yeah. We usually coordinate on social media. It's just a few of us.”

“Alright, I'll give it a thought. I haven't taken an active part in the community so far, so no promises.”

“No pressure. We're not even an official club or something, just a bunch of friends hanging around together.”

“Sounds good to me.”

“May I ask where on the range of the rainbow you see yourself? You really don't have to answer.”

“I don't mind. Well, only my eyes are 'hetero', so to speak.”

Miss Park grins. “Right! Same here. Er, not my eyes, of course, so absolutely nothing hetero about me.” She snorts. Catra chuckles and finds her fingers in her hair again. “By the way,” Miss Park says softly, “your eyes are beautiful.”

Fuck. Catra's jaw drops and her cheeks catch fire. “Uh, wow, I mean, thanks, thank you.”

Miss Park leans a bit backwards. “Oh, was that too much?”

“No, no, it's just–” Catra holds her breath for a second, then exhales deeply and hangs her head. “I've never been told by anyone they like my eyes. Usually people make fun of me because of them.”

“I'm so sorry to hear that. I really meant what I said. Shit, sometimes I hate people.”

Catra catches another hint of lavender.

“And your drawings are also excellent. I can only guess how much work you've put into this collection.”

Catra looks up and is greeted by a supportive smile and a rainbow-coloured hand offering her sketchbook. She takes the book with wide eyes.

“What?” Miss Park says and tilts her head. “Don't say no one has liked your drawings so far.”

“No, that's not it. But people usually say stuff like,” Catra changes to a squeaky voice, “you're so talented.” In normal voice: “Fuck them. I know they probably want to be nice, but fuck them. It took so long to get to this level, to learn all the different skills, to train my eyes to see, you know. I worked so hard to be finally accepted in art college, but rarely anyone acknowledges my effort. So often I was about to just give up and burn it all.” She rubs her forehead. “Sorry for the rant. I don't know, I just feel like you understand me.”

“I do. A few years ago I started to play the piano, just as a hobby. The start was tough. Reading all the notes, getting my fingers in all the right places, not messing up the rhythm? I struggled a lot. When I finally could play some songs I liked in a way I liked, I was proud of myself. Then I played to some people when the opportunity was there, and their feedback was, well, not so charming.” She clears her throat. “I mean, I kind of can't blame them, because I know I'm not able to match professional pianists. Still, it took me months until I had the courage to play again, even by myself. Since then, I'm very picky when it comes to playing for others.”

Catra sighs. “Yeah, I hate it when negative feedback hits me hard. I'm usually my greatest critic and don't need some random person to tell me my work sucks, thank you very much.”

“I'm with you, that's so me.” Miss Park claps her hands on her thighs. “Anyway. You shared your art with me, and I appreciate it. One day, when I'm confident enough and, you know, if you're still around, I'd like to return the favour and play for you.”

“Sounds good to me. No pun intended.” They chuckle.

Miss Park stretches in her seat, brings her arms over her head and behind her back. Catra tries not to stare, instead distracts herself by repeating Miss Park's words in her head. Her statement

seemed casual at first. Now, when Catra thinks about it, it actually conveys trust and commitment. She plucks up her courage. “Hey, uh, I don't know if you noticed there are just half-done portraits in there,” she pats her sketchbook, “that's because I drew them during class and never finish them in time. I tend to get lost in the details. Well, and I'm not exactly the person to, you know, ask some random stranger to sit still for hours so I can draw a portrait. And, uh ...” Catra feels something in Miss Park's expression shift. She probably knows what's coming. Catra's heart races. “If you, you know, happen to stay awhile and read your book or something, maybe I could draw a portrait of you?”

“Me?” Miss Park asks and puts a hand to her chest.

Catra nods. “You can say no, don't feel like you have to because you think I'm a petty loner with no one to draw. Fuck, that even makes it worse.”

Miss Park smiles. “That's not it. I'm just not exactly a model.”

“Are you kidding me?” Catra's eyes go wide. “First of all, everyone can be a model. Sit for me? There, you're a model. Secondly, what's there not to like about your face?”

Miss Park turns her head away and blushes. Her eyes stay fixed on Catra, though.

“Seriously,” Catra says, “you are so expressive, so lively! I could draw you all month from the same perspective without any two portraits being even remotely the same. Sorry if that sounds weird, but there's so much to discover.” *Yep, sounds weird*, Catra thinks.

“Stop it,” Miss Park deflates but giggles. “Your flatteries might actually make me consider it.”

“Sorry, I didn't mean to overstep your boundaries. Sometimes I get pushy when I'm excited. There's nothing you have to be ashamed of. I get there's a lot of pressure, ideal of beauty and stuff. But don't let anyone tell you you're not okay. Besides,

nobody except us gets to see the drawing. I'm rambling, sorry, I'll stop."

Catra straightens her back, closes her eyes and concentrates on her breathing. She hears Miss Park shuffle around, smells lavender. Different bird songs sound from the surrounding garden. Eventually, her mind is at ease. She lets out a final breath and opens her eyes again. Miss Park has copied Catra's posture and looks at her. Her eyes are wide, and the corners of her mouth twitch. She's definitely holding her breath. Catra cannot help it and smirks. Miss Park immediately bursts into laughter, and Catra gladly joins her.

"Well," Miss Park says once she has regained control, "if you're so excited to draw my humble self, I'm not stopping you."

"Really?" Catra tries to sound not too enthusiastically.

"Nobody is allowed to take a look at the drawing?"

"I promise. If you want, you can have it when I'm done."

Miss Park stares at Catra for a while. "Alright. So, what do I have to do?"

Catra smiles. "You can just go ahead and read your book. And be you. You don't have to sit completely still or something. I'm not just a very slow instant camera, so I can handle it."

"I think I can do that." Miss Park reaches for her bag, pulls out her book and opens it in her lap.

Catra finds the first free page in her sketchbook, grabs a pencil and studies Miss Park's facial features. She feels a bit cheap because she openly stares and enjoys doing so, but if she wants to get anything done, there's no way around it. Looking for the general shapes, lines and edges, Catra lets her eyes wander around, studies nose, cheekbone, jawline, brows and lips. She tries her best to not think about those definitely soft, coral lips.

While Catra makes mental notes of the shapes she identifies, she realizes that Miss Park's ears are flushed and her temples bulge. “Hey,” Catra says, “you feel uncomfortable?”

Miss Park gives her a weak smile. “Honestly? It's a little awkward because, well, you don't actually draw anything.”

“Sorry, before I start drawing, I take some time to study and get a feel for the shapes and shadows. It's okay, I'll draw something else.”

“No, I agreed to do it. I can handle it.” Miss Park nods hastily.

“I see you're all tense, and I get it. Having some stranger stare at you is no fun. You don't owe me anything. Maybe when we know each other better.”

“Know each other better?” Miss Park asks cautiously.

“Shit, er, I didn't want to force myself on you. I just figured you ... might be interested? You seem like a nice person.”

Miss Park smiles, genuinely so. “It's okay, I didn't mean to imply I'm not interested, because I am. I just like to make it explicit. To prevent misunderstandings and stuff. So, er, I kind of feel already attached to you? Wow, that sounds awkward. It happens – I tend to talk without thinking when I'm nervous, and I'm obviously doing that right now and – yeah.” She buries her face in her palm. Catra thinks she's cute.

“Thanks for being so open, I appreciate it. When I get nervous, I'm usually irritable. Now that I say that, it's a wonder I haven't insulted you yet. Anyway, don't let my rambling keep you from reading. And I should find something to draw, I haven't made a single stroke today.”

Miss Park nods slowly. “Do you mind if I stay? I'd hate you being disturbed by more unwelcome visitors. Because of this place.” She draws full circles into the air with her hand.

“I don't mind.” Catra scolds herself for being not particularly flirty. She can do better. “I'd be happy if you stay.” A broad smile that makes Catra's stomach dance lights up Miss Park's face. A short soft noise escapes her throat, and she averts Catra's gaze by turning to her book.

Catra shifts on the bench, leans against the backrest and, pencil in hand, tries to focus on the greenery. There's no wind to stir the leaves, and the clear sky provides for even lighting. Everything seems frozen. Catra listens to bird songs once more. And to Miss Park's breathing. Which is a tad too loud and a tad too quick. Also, Catra notices now, not a single page has been turned.

Time to go all in.

Catra closes her eyes for a moment. “So–”

“Yes?” Miss Park's attention immediately turns to Catra. Or has been there all along.

“Does it work?” Catra clears her throat. “You know, this Oak Oracle?” She definitely fails at not blushing.

“Uh, I don't know of any case where it has. I've tried myself. Three times, actually.”

“Right.” Catra nods slowly. “Well, it would kind of freak me out otherwise.” She loses herself in Miss Park's blue eyes. “On the other hand, you never know. Maybe it works next time.”

“Could be, could be.” Miss Park bites her lower lip. “Anyone comes to your mind I could try with?”

Fuck. Catra's palms are sweaty and her breathing too heavy. If she continues at this rate, she's hyperventilating soon. “Well, as chance would have it, there is someone I know. But this person is so nervous right now she can't move, so, you know, I guess you'd have to do all the work.”

Miss Park giggles into her hand. She closes her book and puts it aside. Cross-legged as she sits, she uses her strong arms so slide closer to Catra. She leans in. “I know, tension and stuff,” she whispers, “but consent is important to me, so ...”

Catra's heart races, blood rushes in her ears. “Please, kiss me.”

Miss Park leans closer, and Catra closes her eyes. Their noses touch first. Catra purses her lips slightly to meet those of Miss Park. They are so soft and relaxed that they snuggle around every curve and into every gouge. Their lips separate briefly only to connect again. Catra opens her mouth ever so slightly, allowing their lips to embrace each other. She thinks of the fierce look of Miss Park coming for those scumbags, imagines her fists coming down on them, and revels in the tenderness Miss Park decided to share with her. When Miss Park gently sucks on Catra's lip, she moans.

Miss Park pulls away slowly. Catra moves her head forward to hold onto the kiss until their lips part with a wet sound. Her tongue finds the taste of honey and vanilla. When she opens her eyes, Miss Park gazes at her, pupils dilated, cheeks flushed. Catra bites her lip and breathes deeply.

“Had a vision?” Miss Park whispers.

Catra stares into Miss Park's eyes, yet she sees the heaving of her chest. “Almost.”

“Maybe,” Miss Park swallows, “we need to kiss some more.”

“Yes,” Catra sighs.

“Can I touch your face?”

“Please.”

Miss Park raises her hands. Her fingertips run along Catra's jawline, all the way back, before the balls of her hands, blissfully warm, come down on Catra's cheeks. Catra closes her eyes again

and leans into Miss Park's left palm. She brings her own hand up and strokes the back of Miss Park's. When thumbs caress her skin, Catra purrs.

Holding onto Catra's head, Miss Park pulls her closer gingerly. Catra feels Miss Park's breath on her face before their lips find each other. Admitting herself to be more passionate, Catra nibbles playfully on Miss Park's upper lip who, in return, moans and runs her right hand down Catra's neck.

Although Catra still has her eyes closed, she sees a city dominated by irregular metal structures, rusty and weathered. Warped spires climb into the foggy sky. It feels like home and like a prison. The city fades into nothingness, and Catra is left broken, incomplete. She wants to reach out, hold onto Miss Park, call out for help, but she finds she has no body any more.

Now, she is in a temple of ice, full of icicles and ornate columns. It is freezing and full of tension. Catra is lost in a labyrinth of traps, walls and holes, and she searches for what is missing. When she finds it, a cherry-coloured figurine, it evades her eyes until the temple crumbles and is no more.

She's back in the metal city, now at ease, runs carelessly through wide and narrow corridors, hides in dark corners, sleeps in the comfort of warm company. Home. In the back of her head, Catra knows something is wrong. She tries to uncover the truth, but before long a violent purple vortex sucks everything away she holds dear. When her bare self is all that remains, an excruciating pain shreds her heart and the vortex tears the rest of her apart.

Fragments of her soul reassemble in the blackness of the void. With only a mirror to look at, Catra eyes herself. Her image walks through the corridors she calls home. She watches her phantom being tossed around, trying to escape the prison cell, searching the ice temple. Catra knows what comes next and shouts at the mirror to stops, she begs her other self to turn around, hurls her fists at the cold glass. It's all for nothing, and her phantom

vanishes behind purple clouds. All is black again. Catra falls to her knees.

A figure appears on the other side of the mirror. Their ever-changing shape looks down on Catra in contempt, maybe pity. Or, even worse, indifference. The figure presses a finger on the top of the mirror's frame, pushes gently and knocks it over. Catra covers herself with her arms before she realizes that she is the image herself, trapped in the mirror, tumbling downwards into the abyss.

Blinding white light engulfs her when she splashes into a pool of searing green goo. Metal tubes invade her lungs and wrap around her limbs to hold her in place. Catra fights them, tries to free herself, but the fluid burns her muscles away and leaves her paralysed.

Shining blue eyes appear above the surface. They look at her, fixate on her, spark a fire in her chest that Catra had long forgotten. The fire gives her the strength to reach out. Her arm, however, is engulfed by purple smoke and green liquid, and withdraws quickly. Strong hands find her regardless and pull her out of the pool, free her of the tubes. Catra would rather die than risk tainting those pure eyes and lashes out, fights the hands holding her tightly, no matter how good they feel.

The eyes never let her go. Slowly, they disperse the smoke and evaporate the goo, until finally Catra can breathe again. Until she is home again.

Catra feels like she has lived through a life's worth of memories in a matter of seconds, but she can't remember anything. All that remains is an abundance of emotions that threaten to rip her apart. Luckily, they diminish over time. Eventually, Catra feels her body again. Birds sing their songs. A breeze strokes her face. The chill on her cheeks tell her she's been crying.

As she dares to look at the world, wide blue eyes stare at her. “Fuck,” Catra says. “What the fuck just happened?”

“Catra?”

Shivers run down Catra's spine, and soothing flames heat her chest. As impossible as all this is, she remembers a name. “Hey, Adora.”

Adora gasps, covers her mouth with her right hand and bursts into tears. Catra feels hot streams running down her own face. She extends her right hand and reaches for Adora's cheek. The touch sends tingles along from her fingertips and all the way up to her shoulder. Adora closes her eyes and leans into Catra's palm.

Catra crawls into Adora's lap and slings her legs around Adora's waist. They tightly embrace each other, Adora's head against Catra's chest, and sob violently. Catra fears Adora might literally dissolve into thin air when she lets her go. Even if a part of her insists such a fear is evidence for insanity: given her recent experience, she can't take anything for granted.

The sobs become less and less frequent until they are mostly replaced by snuffles. Adora's hands are stroking Catra's back, and Catra caresses Adora's cheek.

“Is this actually happening?” Adora asks, her head still pressed against Catra's chest.

“I don't know,” Catra says. “But I plan to make the most out of it. Even if I'm hallucinating or fucking insane.”

Adora pulls away just enough for their eyes to meet. Her hands slide down to Catra's waist. “Then kiss me, please.”

Catra leans down and presses her mouth against Adora's. They share tender kisses, passionate kisses, messy kisses. Catra may not remember what Adora likes, but it seems her body does: Adora moans in pleasure, and her scent is so heavy that Catra can taste it on her tongue whenever she inhales through her mouth. She can't wait to get to the source of it.

“I love it when you purr for me,” Adora manages to say between kisses.

“Your scent drives me crazy.” Catra pants. “And I love you.”

“I love you, too.”

“My place or your place?”

“I have two roommates.”

“Then my place,” Catra says. She leaves Adora's lap, breaking the kisses only to allow Adora to stand up. When they both stand in front of the bench, they kiss some more.

“Are we there yet?” Adora asks.

Catra giggles. “Alright, let's get going.” They gather their stuff and dash away, hand in hand.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora runs her fingers through Catra's hair, fondles an ear from time to time and enjoys the soothing purrs that resonate in her chest. When the two of them stormed into Catra's flat and aimed for the bedroom right away, Adora didn't care to look around. Now, after they satisfied each other's needs for the time being, Catra's naked body snuggles against hers, and she lets her eyes wander.

There's not much to see, however. To her left, besides the bed, is a battered hard wood night table with a tissue box on top. The small window just a little further down the wall is covered by light grey curtains with colourful geometric shapes. On the far side of the room stands a wardrobe that has a forest panorama painted on its doors. Adora is curious if Catra did it herself or maybe had a painter friend help her out. Either way, the scenery is very moody with rich green leaves and rays of morning sun breaking through the foliage. She can imagine waking up to this image with the sun shining through the window. The wall to her right is bare except for the door and a light switch.

Adora inhales deeply and releases the air in a long sigh. Catra stirs a little, rubs her cheek on Adora's chest and her leg along Adora's thigh. The tender strokes revive Adora's desires. She moves her hand from Catra's head down to her back. Catra's ears flatten, and she looks up to Adora with widened eyes and furled brows. “Hey,” Adora whispers, “you good?”

Catra presses her head to Adora's chest once more and slings an arm around her. “Yeah,” she says, “I only thought that I still feel like we know each other for ages, but technically have met just today. It kind of freaks me out, because a part of me believes I'm

insane and fears waking up in a shitty psychiatry, sedated and strapped to a bed."

Adora wraps her arms around Catra and holds her close. "I get it. For all I know, I'm real, and I hope you are, too."

"I try not to think about it. But seriously, am I supposed to just accept that we ... Fuck, I don't even have words for it."

"Yeah." Adora tries to wrap her mind around what happened earlier in the park. It seems, though, that the memory of their vision, or whatever it was, fades rather quickly. Just like a dream you remember clearly when waking up, but that around breakfast is already no more than a lingering sentiment.

Adora loosens her hug when Catra shifts and crawls up so their faces are at level. "Can we kiss some more?" Catra asks.

Instead of wording her answer, Adora leans forward and embraces Catra's lips with hers. After a few tame kisses, she rolls over to her side, brings her hand to Catra's back again and presses their bodies together at full length. Their kisses grow more passionate. Adora's heart throbs in her chest while her hand moves down to squeeze Catra's butt. Catra squeaks playfully and in return cups Adora's breast.

"Fuck," Adora moans between kisses.

"Yes."

Adora needs more hands on Catra's body. She wraps her arm around Catra and rolls over to her back again, pulling Catra on top of her. Catra gasps but quickly straddles Adora, resumes fondling her breast and starts kissing her neck. Adora's hands wander all over Catra's backside. When she feels Catra's tail moving upwards her thigh, she says: "Wait a second."

Catra immediately sits up and looks at her with wide eyes and a frown. The concern and surprise Adora sees in Catra's expression

make her smile fondly. “It's okay,” Adora says quickly, “but I need to pee before we get too invested.”

“You really spooked me there for a second,” Catra laughs.

“Sorry, I'll make up for it.” Adora strokes Catra's cheek. Catra leans into the touch. “It warms my heart when you do that,” Adora says.

Catra chuckles. “Wow, you're so mushy.” Despite her words, she presses a hand against Adora's and closes her eyes.

Adora can't stop herself, sits up and hugs Catra. “And you love it.”

“I do,” Catra whispers.

Catra's strong heartbeat sounds in Adora's ear. She enjoys Catra's hands in her hair and on her back, until her bladder reminds her of urgent business. “Show me the bathroom?”

They separate and get out of bed. Catra silently takes Adora's hand in hers and leads her into the bathroom. Like the bedroom, it is rather small, yet there's enough space to house a bathtub and a washing machine.

Adora sits down on the toilet seat, only to find Catra on her lap again, stealing more kisses. “Catra,” Adora says while holding onto Catra's waist.

“Yes, Adora?”

“As much as I enjoy your attention, I can't pee when you excite me like that.”

Catra breaks the kisses and snickers. “Sorry.” She cradles Adora's head to her chest and starts to purr. “Better?”

Adora entwines Catra's back and sighs. “Wonderful.” Relief comes eventually and noisily.

“Good girl,” Catra whispers after silence has settled in.

The tease sends shivers down Adora's spine. She's surprised and embarrassed by her reaction, not ready to explore this further, yet, and giggles.

“I'll go next,” Catra says and gets up. Adora wipes herself and goes to the sink, and Catra takes her place on the seat. As soon as Adora has washed and dried her hands, Catra reaches out for her with a pleading look.

“Hey,” Adora says and takes Catra's hand in hers, “questioning reality again?”

Catra nods. “It's not so frightening if we touch.”

Adora squats down and strokes Catra's thigh with her free hand. “If you're still up for it, I can think of a distraction that requires a lot of touching.”

“You're insatiable, aren't you?” Catra smirks.

Seeing Catra light up like that again, Adora smiles and squeezes Catra's hand. She gets up and brings her mouth to whisper into Catra's ear. “Can you blame me when my girlfriend is so hot?” Catra moans, and when Adora stands up, she sees Catra bite her lip with closed eyes. “As soon as you're done here,” Adora says, “I don't plan to leave the bed until I pass out.”

Catra gasps, quickly wipes herself and rushes to the sink. Adora wraps her arms around Catra's waist from the back while Catra washes and dries her hands. As soon as she's done, Adora scoops Catra up, making her squeal, and heads off to the bedroom.

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Adora wakes to her ringtone. She tries to groan, but her throat is so dry she instead wheezes. When she slowly turns around to search the floor for her phone, Catra shift behind her and

grumbles. By the time Adora finds the phone inside her bag, Catra snuggles against her back.

The display's blinding light makes it impossible for Adora to see who's calling or what time it is. She accepts the call and coughs as a greeting. “Hello?” she manages eventually.

“Finally! Where are you?” It's Glimmer. She sounds pissed. “Are you alright?” Now she's concerned.

Adora rubs her face, which is quite a challenge with Catra impeding her movements. She nearly drops the phone in the process. “I'm alright. What's up?”

“What's up?” Glimmer's back to being pissed. “I've been waiting for you for almost two hours. You didn't answer my messages or my calls. And now you sound like you just got out of bed. That's up.”

“Waiting for me?” Adora tries to remember. *Fuck, her essay.* “Fuck, your essay.”

“Yes, fuck my essay, I'm glad you at least remember.”

“I'm so sorry, Glimmer. Let me, uh, how about ...” Adora can't think straight.

“I'm still waiting.”

Adora groans. “Look, I got into some really crazy shit today, and I'm all worn out. First thing tomorrow morning, I'll review your essay, okay? Just send it to me.”

“Already did. Like, three hours ago.”

“Yeah, I get it, I'm sorry. I'll explain everything tomorrow. When do you get up? I'll have it done by then.”

Glimmer grunts. “Fine! You better have a good story to tell and an even better review at hand.” She sighs. “I'll be ready at seven

thirty.”

“I'll be there in time.”

“You better be.” Glimmer gasps. “Wait, you're not coming until tomorrow? Where are you staying tonight? What the fuck, Adora?”

“See you tomorrow, love you!” Adora feels Catra tighten the grip around her waist.

Glimmer has the last word: “Adora!”

Adora hangs up, exhales and caresses Catra's hand. “Sorry, didn't mean to wake you.”

Catra takes a while to respond. “You love her?” Her voice is shaking slightly.

Adora feels panic rise. “Not like you!” She turns over to face Catra and cups her cheek while bringing their foreheads together. “Not like you. She's my roommate. We're very close, but only as friends.” The tip of Catra's tail dances along Adora's leg. “Also she's straight and in a relationship.”

“So, you're not seeing anyone?”

“Of course not. I promise.” Catra releases the breath she must have been holding. Adora thinks about what made Catra question their relationship's status. “Right, we didn't talk about it. There's only you and me. Or do you ...”

“No,” Catra says and shifts closer. “Only you and me.”

“Glad to hear.” They share a few kisses.

“I'm dying of thirst.”

“Me too, thanks to our workout.” They chuckle. “I'll show you the kitchen.”

They get out of bed and into their underwear before heading for the kitchen, hands clasped.

“So,” Catra says after downing a glass of water. “What was the call about?”

Adora sighs. “I agreed to work through an essay of Glimmer, who called. But, you know, I had other things on my mind today. And on me.” She grins and steals a kiss. “Well, it's due in two days already, so I promised to review the essay until tomorrow morning at seven thirty. So I'll need to get up at around four.”

Catra's eyes go wide. “In the middle of the night?”

“It's not that bad. I rise early, though usually not *that* early.”

“But it's already – I don't know, but it's almost dark outside.”

Adora scratches her head. “Yeah. It's shy of nine, but I can't help it, I fucked that up.”

“Really?” Catra smirks. “I don't remember an essay there with us in bed.”

Adora laughs before locking their lips.

“So, what's your plan?” Catra says while snuggling against Adora.

“I'm so exhausted, I might just collapse into bed. But I'm also starving and can cope with a little sleep deprivation. So how about we order some dinner first?”

“Sounds good.”

Adora has a few recommendations, and they settle on falafel, pita and mixed salads. “I've been thinking about,” Adora says while they wait for the food, “how to tell my friends what happened to us today. But I don't see a way to explain, well, us being so close yet having met just today. It crossed my mind to not tell anybody until we can pretend to have actually dated for some time. So that

us” – she leans to Catra – “being so crazy” – she kisses her – “in love” – kiss – “with each other” – more kisses – “is only crazy in the cute way, not outright insane.”

Catra sighs and hugs Adora tightly. “I see where you're coming from, but that'd be hard to pull off with me hanging around all the time.”

“Yeah,” Adora chuckles. She's surprised at herself for not worrying about the clinginess and neediness in Catra's statement. Instead, she feels warm and fuzzy inside and is totally content with letting things happen. “Also I'm a bad liar and wouldn't last a single day.” She strokes Catra's hair. “Do you have a better idea?”

“I don't know. Until now, I've never bonded with people enough to really care about what they think of me.”

Adora feels a sting in her chest. “I'm sorry.”

Catra pulls her head back and looks at her sternly. “Don't be, for I surely am not. I've managed fine on my own, and my energy usually drains quickly around other people.” She clears her throat and continues talking quickly to Adora's chest: “You're the only exception. Ever.” Her tail wraps around Adora's leg.

Adora hugs Catra tightly and kisses her head. “That's so sweet of you.”

“Anyway. Just saying that maybe I'm not in the position to give advice.”

“I think you did nevertheless.”

“Did I?”

“Yes,” Adora says. “You reminded me of how important it is to keep those people close you feel comfortable around. I trust my friends, and while they probably will have a hard time believing our story, I'm sure they get the hang of it quickly. They just need to get to know you and see we're not making anything up.” Adora

feels Catra tense up. “Hey, you okay with meeting my friends? We don't have to rush anything.”

Catra exhales. “It shouldn't bother me, but I panicked there for a second they might not like me and, you know, talk you into not seeing me again.”

“Whoa, I'm not giving in that easily. I trust my friends, but I know when to stand my ground.”

“That's what I said myself. I'm going to trust you there, didn't mean to talk your fortitude down. Sorry.”

Adora calms herself down and runs a hand along Catra's back. “No, I'm sorry. It's a weak spot of mine, having my independence questioned.”

Catra chuckles.

“What?” Adora asks. “Did I say something funny?”

“No, I just realized that's been our first argument or whatever. That's a sign we're not trapped in a dream, I guess?” Catra rubs her cheek on Adora's chest and purrs.

“I can't believe how much that thought turns me on.” Adora joins Catra's giggles.

“I'll come meet your friends,” Catra says and earns a smooch to her head.

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Five minutes before the appointed meeting with Glimmer, Adora and Catra step into the stairwell of Adora's place. The walk over from Catra's flat took them about twenty minutes, mostly because Catra was so tired that Adora felt like having to drag her all the way. They barely talked, but they got to hold hands at least.

“Ugh, there's no elevator?” Catra grumbles.

“Nope, sorry.”

“Which floor?”

Adora knows Catra's not going to like the answer. “Seventh.”

“What the fuck? What kind of building this tall doesn't have a fucking elevator?” At least Catra seems to be more energized now. Alas, not for long: her body goes slack with a groan.

“I'm sorry you had to get up so early just to meet my friends,” Adora tries to comfort Catra and kisses her cheek.

“Yeah, hand me a medal.” Catra sighs. “My muscles are all sore from yesterday.”

An idea sparks Adora's mind. “I can give you a lift.” She smirks.

Catra looks at her with wide beautiful eyes. “What? You want to carry me?”

Adora nods.

“Up to the seventh floor?”

Adora grins.

Catra blows her cheeks out and raises her eyebrows. Then her face relaxes, and she brings her arms up sideways.

Adora giggles, lifts Catra into her arms and runs up the stairs, taking two steps at once.

Catra squeaks. “Hold your horses! If you keep this pace up, you'll get a heart attack.”

Glancing at Catra, Adora notices the intense flush on her cheeks. “I can do it.” After two floors, however, she sweats and pants and has to slow down considerably.

“Adora, as fun as it is to see us both getting wet from you carrying me, I'm fine with walking.”

Spurred by Catra's casual confession, Adora keeps going. She wants to come up with a witty response, but she fails and decides to save the breath anyway. Catra does not protest. Instead, she bites her lip and intently watches Adora.

The last flight of stairs demands all of Adora's willpower. Eventually, she reaches the seventh floor, gently sets Catra down before falling onto her hands and knees, puffing madly. Catra runs the tip of her fingers playfully along Adora's back which sends shivers along her spine.

“Damn, Adora,” Catra says, “don't expect me to ever do that for you.” She lowers her voice. “I wouldn't mind you making me drip like this, though.”

Indeed, sweat trickles from Adora's forehand, and the clingy feel on her torso tells her she soaked her shirt. She rolls over to her back, moving into spread-eagle. “Told you I can do it,” she manages between breaths.

Catra strikes an upright pose and takes her phone out of her pocket with a stern look on her face. With a single finger, she shoves imaginary glasses up her nose. “According to my readings,” she says in an even voice, “the lack of oxygen in your cardiovascular system, Miss Adora, will require prolonged horizontal alignment of yours, causing you to miss your scheduled appointment.” She turns around her phone – the display says “7:29”.

Adora snickers. If she weren't so exhausted, she'd immediately have her hands and lips all over Catra again. Instead, she reaches out with her hands.

Catra lowers her chin almost down to her chest. “Heavy lifting is not part of my job description.”

“I'm not fat,” Adora wails playfully and pouts. Catra chuckles, tucks her phone and helps Adora get up. Still lacking air, Adora bends over, hands ob her knees, and puffs some more.

“Hate to say it, but you mopped the floor thoroughly with your shirt. You should probably change and take a shower anyway. Let me know if you need any assistance with that.”

Adora snorts. “So that's part of your job description?”

“Of course, dummy,” Catra says softly before kissing Adora's neck.

Finally, Adora stands up entirely and shakes her legs. “I probably won't do that again.”

“What a shame.”

“But I could.”

Catra smiles and kisses Adora's cheek. “Alright, lets go.”

Adora stiffly walks along the corridor and fumbles for the keys. Eventually, she unlocks the door and enters the flat with Catra right behind her.

Glimmer is already waiting for her with crossed arms. “You're late,” she says. Before Adora can reply, Glimmer's face lights up. “Oh, hi, Catra!”

“Hey, Sparkles.”

The three of them stare at each other for a while before they start screaming and engage into a Best Friend Squad hug. As crazy as their life became, it seems that Adora's friends will have no trouble accepting her new relationship. Catra will fit in perfectly.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading! Please let me know what you think, what you liked and what you didn't like. I'm aiming for improving

my craft and always appreciate constructive criticism.

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